old image as a ruling politician given to high performance. Perhaps it was part of his unspoken oneupmanship with Tejashwi's Rashtriya Janata Dal, perhaps even thoughts of New Delhi were germinating in the subsoil. Either way, a newly hyperactive Nitish is what Bihar was being treated to. The 72-year-old patriarch of the Janata Dal (United) had always been an early riser. But of late, he has been beginning his day even earlier, completing his morning walk and yoga by 5.30 am, unmindful of the mild winter chill. Seated in his office by 8.30 am, scanning newspapers and files, often venturing out after 9.20 am, stalking the secretariat corridors, checking if the ministers and bureaucrats had taken their seats, dishing out an earful to the missing ones—it's all been in sync with his 'sushaasan babu' image.

Not just government offices, even his party office witnessed Nitish's 'surprise' visits quite frequently. On November 4, Nitish was there at 9 am, taking a quiet tour of the premises like a razor-sharp CEO, when not even a single party worker was around. The overdrive is not arbitrary. With less than six months left for the Lok Sabha election, he knows the first-mover advantage he derived with Bihar's caste survey can be optimised only with solid follow-up action on the ground.

His focused vigil had an impact. Within 11 days of his cabinet approving the twofold hike in salaries of over 30,000 teachers tasked with adult education among Dalits and vocational training of Muslim girls, the education department issued the relevant notification. The recruitment of over 120,000 teachers by November 2, moving to top that off with another 69,000 teachers and 20,000 police personnel, appointing members to the 20-point programme implementation committees in all districts, constituting various boards and corporations, Nitish had been ticking all the boxes.

On the political front, preparations are on for a Bheem Sansad, a congregation of Bihar's Dalit population on November 26, and all three JD(U) ministers from the community—Choudhary, Sunil Kumar and Ratnesh Sada—have been tasked with mobilising crowds for the mega event. That's of a piece with his core politics. Even if the BJP took a leaf out of it and started championing the sub-categorisation of castes as a way to break the stranglehold of OBC- and Dalit-dominant parties, the original idea was Nitish's. In fact, in his very first term as CM (2005-10), he had succeeded in winning over a large section of the Dalit population by carving out 21 sub-castes as Mahadalits and bestowing on them targeted social welfare schemes. Thus, he developed political capital among the Ravidas (5.3 per cent of Bihar's population), Musahar (3.1 per cent), Panar (1.7 per cent) and Pasi (nearly 1 per cent) communities among others, thus effectively neutralising the numerical dominance of Paswans (5.3 per cent), the biggest SC group that traditionally backs the late Ram Vilas Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party (LJP). Likewise, he carved out a support base among EBCs, separating them from the dominant OBC groups like Yadavs.

How much the assembly gaffe will harm Bihar's longest-serving CM remains to be seen. The BJP—with which he severed ties last year—is anyway eager to sing a swan song for him, and new partner RJD fancies Tejashwi as his successor after the 2025 assembly polls. Keeping an eagle eye on INDIA's progress, Nitish had on November 2 also expressed his displeasure over the Congress's apparent preoccupation with the assembly polls in five states and the resultant sluggish pace of seat-sharing talks. Two days later, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge called Nitish to reaffirm his party's commitment. That hard-earned stature is at stake. As a top JD(U) leader says, "The good news for us is that Nitishji excels in pressure situations." He will surely need that skill right now. ■



ANI

A HAPPY BUNCH Newly recruited teachers with appointment letters distributed by Nitish at Gandhi Maidan, Nov. 2

NITISH KNOWS HIS CASTE SURVEY'S FIRST-MOVER ADVANTAGE CAN WORK ONLY IF WELFARE SCHEMES ARE PROPERLY IMPLEMENTED